# "Rip It Out"

## Peter Weir

### About Peter Weir

Peter Lindsay Weir is one of Australia's most celebrated film directors and screenwriters. Born in 1944, Weir gained international recognition for his thoughtful and visually striking films that explore individuality, society, and human experience. His major works include *Picnic at Hanging Rock, Gallipoli, Witness, Dead Poets Society, The Truman Show,* and *Master and Commander: The Far Side of the World*. Throughout his career, Weir received multiple Academy Award nominations for Best Director and was honoured with an Honorary Oscar in 2022 for his outstanding contribution to world cinema.

### *Dead Poets Society*

*Dead Poets Society* is a coming-of-age drama directed by Peter Weir and released in 1989. Set in 1950s in an elite boarding school for boys called Welton Academy, the film follows English teacher Robin Williams as John Keating, who inspires his students to think independently, appreciate poetry, and "seize the day." The film is widely admired for its themes of self-discovery, freedom, and the transformative power of education. It received four Academy Award nominations, including Best Picture and Best Director, and won the Oscar for Best Original Screenplay. The film also won the BAFTA Award for Best Film and remains a popular educational and cultural classic.



The part prescribed for study in the syllabus is a six-minute excerpt from the film *Dead Poets Society*, popularly known as the "Rip It Out" scene. Please watch the excerpt on YouTube by scanning the provided QR code. You are also encouraged to watch the complete film in advance.

## Transcript of the Movie Excerpt

KEATING
Gentlemen, open your texts to page 21 of this introduction. Mr. Perry, will you read the opening paragraph of the preface entitled "Understanding Poetry"?

NEIL
"'Understanding Poetry,' by Dr. J. Evans Pritchard, Ph.D. To fully understand poetry, we must first be fluent with its meter, rhyme and figures of speech, then ask two questions: 1) How artfully has the objective of the poem been rendered and 2) How important is that objective? Question 1 rates the poem's perfection; question 2 rates its importance. And once these questions have been answered, determining the poem's greatness becomes a relatively simple matter. If the poem's score for perfection is plotted on the horizontal of a graph and its importance is plotted on the vertical, then calculating the total area of the poem yields the measure of its greatness. A sonnet by Byron might score high on the vertical but only average on the horizontal. A Shakespearean sonnet, on the other hand, would score high both horizontally and vertically, yielding a massive total area, thereby revealing the poem to be truly great. As you proceed through the poetry in this book, practice this rating method. As your ability to evaluate poems in this matter grows, so will, so will your enjoyment and understanding of poetry."

KEATING
Excrement. That's what I think of Mr. J. Evans Pritchard. We're not laying pipe. We're talking about poetry. How can you describe poetry like American Bandstand? "Oh, I like Byron. I give him a 42, but I can't dance to it." Now, I want you to rip out that page. Go on. Rip out the entire page. You heard me. Rip it out. Rip it out! Go on. Rip it out!

[Charles rips out the page] Thank you, Mr. Dalton. Gentlemen, tell you what. Don't just tear out that page, tear out the entire introduction. I want it gone. History. Leave nothing of it. Rip it out! Rip! Be gone, J. Evans Pritchard, Ph.D. Rip. Shred. Tear. Rip it out! I want to hear nothing but ripping of Mr. Pritchard. We'll perforate it, put it on a roll. It's not the Bible. You're not gonna go to Hell for this. Go on. Make a clean tear. I want nothing left of it.

RICHARD:
We shouldn't be doing this.

KEATING:
Rip! Rip! Rip! Rip it out! Rip! Rip it out! [Enter McCallister]

McALLISTER:
What the hell is going on here?

KEATING:
I don't hear enough rips!

McALLISTER:
Mr. Keating.

KEATING
Mr. McAllister.

McALLISTER
I'm sorry. I-- I didn't know you were here.

KEATING
I am.

McALLISTER
Ah, so you are. Excuse me.

KEATING
Keep ripping, gentlemen! This is a battle. A war. And the casualties could be your hearts and souls. Thank you, Mr. Dalton. Armies of academics going forward, measuring poetry. No! We'll not have that here. No more Mr. J. Evans Pritchard. Now, my class, you will learn to think for yourselves again. You will learn to savor words and language. No matter what anybody tells you, words and ideas can change the world. I see that look in Mr. Pitt's eye, like nineteenth

century literature has nothing to do with going to business school or medical school. Right? Maybe. Mr. Hopkins, you may agree with him, thinking "Yes, we should simply study our Mr. Pritchard and learn our rhyme and meter and go quietly about the business of achieving other ambitions." I have a little secret for ya. Huddle up. Huddle up!

KEATING
We don't read and write poetry because it's cute. We read and write poetry because we are members of the human race. And the human race is filled with passion. Medicine, law, business, engineering, these are all noble pursuits, and necessary to sustain life. But poetry, beauty, romance, love, these are what we stay alive for. To quote from Whitman: "O me, o life of the questions of these recurring, of the endless trains of the faithless, of cities filled with the foolish. What good amid these, o me, o life? Answer: that you are here. That life exists, and identity. That the powerful play goes on, and you may contribute a verse. That the powerful play goes on and you may contribute a verse.

KEATING
What will your verse be?

## Summary of the “Rip It Out” Scene

The “Rip It Out” scene from the movie *Dead Poets Society* (1989) introduces the teaching philosophy of Mr. John Keating and establishes one of the central themes of the film. Set in the strict and tradition-bound environment of the elite boarding school Welton Academy, the scene portrays Keating’s first English literature class. This scene, as well as the film as a whole, challenges conventional methods of education and encourages students to think independently.

The scene features a classroom where Keating asks a student to read the preface to the poetry textbook, *Understanding Poetry*, written by Dr. J. Evans Pritchard. The passage presents a highly technical approach to literary criticism. According to Pritchard, the greatness of a poem can be measured scientifically by analysing its structure, rhyme, meter, and thematic importance. He even suggests using graphs and mathematical formulas to evaluate poetry. As the student reads aloud, Keating draws a graph on the blackboard, and the students dutifully copy it into their notebooks. This moment highlights how students have been trained to accept information without questioning it.

Once the reading is complete, Keating surprises the class by instructing them to tear the pages out of their textbooks. The students are initially shocked because such an action is unheard of in the disciplined atmosphere of Welton Academy. However, Keating insists, arguing that poetry cannot be reduced to charts, formulas, or numerical measurements. He famously remarks, “We are not laying pipe; we are talking about poetry.” By asking the students to rip out the pages, he symbolically rejects rigid academic methods that attempt to reduce art to a mechanical process. The act of tearing the pages becomes a gesture of intellectual freedom and resistance against unquestioned authority.

Keating explains that they are engaged in a struggle against those who “sterilize” poetry by treating it as a scientific object rather than a living form of expression. He wants his students to experience literature personally and emotionally rather than merely memorizing critical theories. His goal is not to make them experts in literary terminology but to help them discover the power of language and imagination. He tells them that in his class they will learn to think for themselves and to “savour words and language.”

The scene then moves beyond the study of poetry and becomes a lesson about life itself. Keating recognizes that many of his students view literature as irrelevant to their future careers in medicine, law, or business. In response, he argues that while professions such as engineering, medicine, and law are necessary for sustaining society, they are not the sole purpose of human existence. Poetry, beauty, romance, love, and passion are equally important because they give meaning to life. According to Keating, human beings are driven not only by practical needs but also by dreams, emotions, and creativity.

To reinforce his message, Keating quotes the American poet Walt Whitman.

> "Oh me! Oh life! of the questions of these recurring,
>
> Of the endless trains of the faithless, of cities fill'd with the foolish,
>
> The question, O me! so sad, recurring-What good amid these, O me, O life?
>
> Answer.
>
> That you are here that life exists and identity,
>
> That the powerful play goes on, and you may contribute a verse."

The lines emphasize that every individual has a unique role to play in the “powerful play” of life and that each person can “contribute a verse.” This quotation captures the

film's central message: individuals should discover their own identity and make meaningful contributions to the world rather than simply conforming to social expectations.

The "Rip It Out" scene is therefore much more than a classroom incident. It serves as a declaration of Keating's educational philosophy and introduces the film's major themes of individuality, creativity, self-expression, and nonconformity. By encouraging students to question authority and think independently, Keating inspires them to see poetry, and thus life, from a new perspective. The scene remains one of the most powerful moments in the film because it reminds viewers that education should not merely transmit information; it should awaken curiosity, imagination, and a sense of purpose.

## Short Analysis

The "Rip It Out" scene is one of the most memorable and significant moments in *Dead Poets Society* (1989). It introduces the teaching philosophy of Mr. John Keating and highlights some of the film's central themes, including the value of independent thinking, the power of effective communication, and the importance of the arts in human life. Set in the conservative environment of Welton Academy, the scene challenges traditional educational methods and encourages students to question accepted beliefs.

One of the most striking aspects of the scene is the effectiveness of Keating's speech. The students at Welton have been raised in a culture that values discipline, obedience, and professional success above all else. Most of them view poetry as an unimportant subject that must simply be studied to pass examinations. Keating understands their attitude and uses a dynamic teaching method to capture their attention. Rather than beginning with a conventional lecture, he asks them to perform a physical action—tearing out the introduction to their poetry textbook. This unexpected act immediately arouses curiosity and breaks the routine of classroom learning.

Keating's speech is effective because it combines action, emotion, and persuasion. He directly addresses the thoughts of his students, anticipating their doubts about the usefulness of poetry. By doing so, he establishes a connection with his audience and makes them feel understood. He also uses powerful language, declaring that "words and ideas can change the world." His quotation from the poetry of Walt Whitman provides an emotional and philosophical conclusion to his argument. The students, who were initially confused and sceptical, gradually become attentive and inspired. The scene demonstrates how a skilled speaker can influence attitudes and encourage people to reconsider their assumptions.

A second important aspect of the scene is its emphasis on thinking differently. The textbook introduction by Dr. J. Evans Pritchard attempts to measure the value of poetry through charts, formulas, and technical analysis. Keating rejects this approach because he believes that poetry cannot be reduced to numbers and graphs. For him, poetry is a living expression of human emotions, imagination, and experience. By asking the students to tear out the page, he symbolically rejects blind acceptance of authority and encourages them to form their own judgments.

The scene also conveys a broader message about life. Keating argues that professions such as medicine, law, engineering, and business are necessary and valuable, but they are not the only things that matter. Poetry, beauty, love, passion, and creativity give meaning to human existence. Through this argument, the film suggests that education should not merely prepare students for careers; it should also help them understand themselves and the world around them.

Overall, the “Rip It Out” scene serves as a powerful critique of rigid educational systems and a celebration of intellectual freedom. It teaches that true learning begins when individuals question assumptions, think independently, and remain open to the beauty and complexity of life. The scene remains relevant because it encourages students to balance practical ambitions with creativity, self-expression, and critical thinking.

## Questions

### Answer the following questions in a sentence or two:

1. What are the important aspects that make a poem great according to the article read out in the class?

Hint: Meter, rhyme, figures of speech, structure, technical perfection, measurable qualities.

2. Why does Mr. Keating ask the learners to tear off the article from their book?

Hint: Rejects mechanical analysis; encourages independent thinking; poetry cannot be measured by formulas and graphs.

3. What does Mr. Keating want his learners to learn in his class?

Hint: Think for themselves; appreciate language; enjoy poetry; develop individuality and creativity.

4. What opinion do most of the learners in class have about studying poetry?

Hint: Consider it unimportant; study only because it is prescribed; focus on future careers.

5. Why do we read and write poetry, according to Mr. Keating?

Hint: Human beings are filled with passion; poetry gives meaning to life; celebrates beauty, love, and emotions.

### Answer the following questions in 150 words each:

1. Explain Mr. Keating's words, "we are not laying pipes, we are talking about poetry."

Hint: Contrast between technical work and artistic expression · Poetry cannot be reduced to formulas and ‘geometrical’ analysis · Importance of imagination, emotions, and personal experience.

2. How does Mr. Keating explain the difference between courses like medicine and engineering and studying poetry?

Hint: Medicine and engineering sustain life · Poetry, beauty, romance, and love make life meaningful · Practical needs versus human values and passions.

3. What do the reactions of the learners to Mr. Keating suggest about their inner confusions and growth?

Hint: Initial shock and hesitation · Curiosity develops · Begin questioning old beliefs · Openness to new ideas · Intellectual and emotional awakening.

4. What have you learned about the power of good speaking skills from the scene?

Hint: Engages audience through action and emotion · Understands listeners' thoughts · Uses persuasive language and examples · Inspires change in attitudes and thinking.

### Answer the following questions in 300 words each:

1. Discuss the significance of the "Rip It Out" scene in *Dead Poets Society*. How does the scene challenge traditional educational methods and promote independent thinking among students?

Hints: Keating introduces non-traditional teaching · Symbolic act: tearing textbook page · Critique of rote learning and rigid analysis of poetry · Emphasis on imagination over formulas/graphs · Shift from conformity to individuality · Student reaction: surprise → reflection · Central idea: education as freedom of thought.

2. Analyse Mr. Keating's speech in the "Rip It Out" scene. How does he use language, persuasion, and poetry to change his students' attitudes towards literature and life?

Hints: Starts with shock method (physical action of ripping pages) · Uses simple, persuasive, emotional language · Addresses students' doubts directly · Rejects technical view of poetry · Highlights poetry as expression of human passion · Whitman quotation for philosophical depth · Inspires shift in attitude and awareness · Shows power of effective communication.

## Voice Recording Exercise (Character Reflection Task)

Please select one character from the "Rip It Out" scene (e.g., Neil Perry, Todd Anderson, Charlie Dalton, or Mr. Keating) and submit a **3–5 minute audio or video recording** from that character's perspective.

**Task focus:**

- Recreate the scene from the chosen character's inner voice
- Express confusion, resistance, or acceptance of Keating's act

- Reflect on conformity vs individuality
- End with a personal opinion on Keating's teaching method

**Skills developed:**

- Fluency and spoken coherence
- Emotional expression and voice modulation
- Reflective and imaginative speaking

You can record using mobile phones and review it yourself to evaluate your fluency, spoken coherence, expression, and voice modulation.